

Here's one way to look at it: A bolt-hole of your own is like an insurance policy. Maybe you won't need it. But if you do need it, you'll need it very, very badly.

Of course, if an asteroid strikes the Earth or if the Yellowstone volcano blows up or if government goons go through the countryside, as the Soviets did in the Ukraine, torturing peasants to find out where they had hidden grain, even a family farm of your own may not save you. But in the case of many other calamities, it might make the difference between life and death.

"You're just looking at the negative side of it," adds Elizabeth. On the positive side, a family stronghold can give you a richer family life. You need a place that gives your family a sense of identity, unity, and stability. Generations come and go. But places last. A place gives a family a sense of permanence, too:

Family strongholds help families develop their own culture . . . their own resources . . . their own histories. They are good places to get the family together for holidays, for reunions and to help family members learn to work together. They're places that you remember, no matter where you go or where you live. They're places where grandparents live. Where family portraits and family papers are stored. Places you think about. Places where you bury your gold.

A family stronghold or a refuge is also a good place to retreat to, to recover and to think. It should be fully paid for, of course. You don't want to have to worry about it. It should be a real stronghold where you're safe. And where you're happy. So if you lose your job, for example, it's a place where you go back to, to take time to think about your next move. Or if you want to write a book or invent a new computer app or just try to figure out what's going on in your life, a family stronghold is a good place to do it. It should be quiet, tranquil, and protective.

We recovered the family farm in Maryland last year, after spending 15 years in Europe. The place was a mess: overgrown with trees and bushes, with fallen-down fences and grown-up fields, cracked and rotting shutters on the house, and barn roofs that you could see daylight through.

Almost every weekend since, we've spent fixing the place up. Sometimes just Edward (the last child still living with us) would be available to help.